

CENTRAL AMERICA



SEVEN SMALL COUNTRIES make up Central America, a tapering neck of land that connects northern North America to South America. The Pacific Ocean lies to the west, and the Caribbean Sea, an arm of the Atlantic Ocean, lies to the east. The two oceans are connected by the Panama Canal, a short cut that saves ships months of sailing time. The original peoples of Central America were Native Americans, conquered by the Spaniards in the 1500s. Since gaining independence, these countries have had periods of turbulent politics and unstable economies.

Physical features

Central America has a backbone of rugged volcanic peaks and massive crater lakes that run from Guatemala down to Costa Rica. The Pacific coast is flat and fertile, and the eastern lowlands, stretching to the Caribbean Sea, are wild, empty swamps and rainforests, with little cultivation.

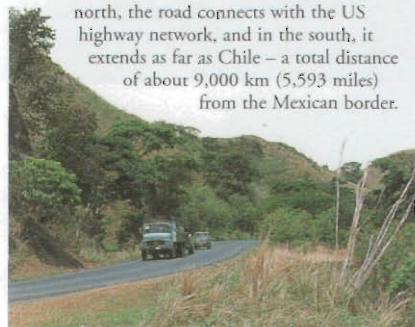


Tropical rainforest

The hot, tropical climate and high rainfall of Central America's Caribbean coast gives rise to vast areas of dense rainforest, particularly in Belize and Guatemala, and on Nicaragua's Mosquito Coast. Economic pressure is forcing people to cut and clear parts of the forest for crops.

Sierra Madre

The Sierra Madre is the highland region of Guatemala and El Salvador, and is a continuation of the Sierra Madre of Mexico. It includes Tajumulco, an extinct volcano, which, at 4,220 m (13,845 ft), is the highest peak in Central America. Most Guatemalans live in this cooler region.



Pan-American Highway, Costa Rica